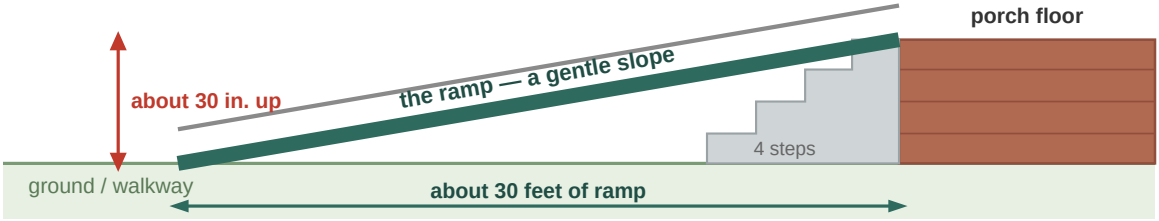
Getting Up the Front Steps — Without the Steps

A wheelchair ramp for **240 12th St, Connellsville** — what it is, how long it has to be, and what it costs. Written in plain English, no construction experience needed.

1. The situation

The front porch sits about **2½ feet (28–30 inches)** above the walkway, up **4 concrete steps**. A wheelchair can't climb steps, so the ramp takes their place: a gentle slope from the ground up to the porch floor.

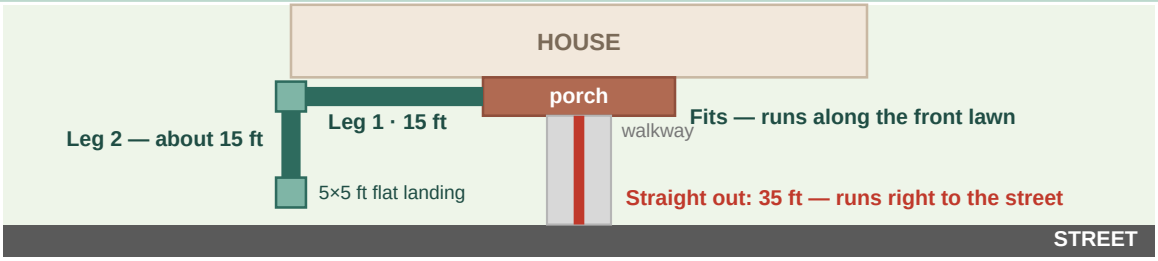


Side view: the ramp rises the same 30 inches as the steps, stretched out over 30 feet.

2. The one rule: 1 inch up = 1 foot of ramp

1 inch of height → 1 foot of ramp.

That's the safety rule. Think driveway, not ski jump: gentle enough to push a wheelchair up without a struggle, and slow enough coming down. Any steeper is hard work going up and unsafe coming down. That's why this porch needs about **30 feet of ramp** — 30 inches up, one foot per inch. Each end needs a flat **5×5 ft resting spot**, so there's room to stop, turn, and open the front door.



Top view: a straight ramp would reach the street, so it turns a corner instead — an L-shape along the front lawn.

3. Your options

Option	Typical cost*	What to know
Modular aluminum	**$4,500 – $7,500**	**Best choice for most buyers.** Put up in 1–2 days, no concrete. Unbolts and moves with you — or rent one for $150–$500 a month.
Wood	**$3,500 – $8,000**	Cheaper to build, but needs regular upkeep and gets slippery in winter.
Concrete	**$7,000+**	Permanent and solid — but it stays with the house forever.
Platform lift	**$4,000 – $10,000+**	A small outdoor elevator. The backup plan if the yard can't fit a 30-foot ramp. Needs electricity and yearly service.

**2026 estimates for a ramp this size, installed, with handrails. Not quotes — an installer gives the exact price after seeing the house.*

Help paying for it

- **PHFA ACCESS loan:** $1,000–$10,000, no interest, no monthly payment — paid back only when the house is sold. Ask your lender whether it fits your loan.
- **Fayette County Area Agency on Aging:** installs ramps for residents — worth a call.
- **Medicare does not pay for ramps.** A Medicaid waiver sometimes does.

Before you build

- A section of the porch railing opens where the ramp meets the porch.
- Check with the Connellsville code office about a permit — permanent ramps usually need one.
- Handrails on both sides; non-slip surface for rain and snow.

The next step: measure the porch height with a tape measure — from the walkway up to the porch floor. Every inch of height = one foot of ramp, so that one number sets the length.